The talks began in Beijing on 31 December 1953 with a meeting between the Indian delegation led by T.N. Kaul and Premier Zhou Enlai. Here Zhou reiterated that outstanding issues could be solved only on the basis of mutual respect for sovereignty and territorial integrity; in other words, it could not be decided on the basis of unequal treaties that Great Britain had forced upon Tibet or China. But even more significantly, Zhou said that only those questions would be taken up for discussion that 'are ripe for settlement'. [36] These were carefully chosen words. In the course of their systematic research, they began to understand the complexity of the boundary issue as well as the Indian thinking. In October 1953, the Chinese central government's representative in Lhasa, General Zhang Jingwu, opined that India 'claimed the absence of territorial disputes just to force us into implicitly acknowledging and legitimizing their occupation. We must stay alert in this regard.' His advice was to delay the settlement of the border issue, but to engage India on all other matters relating to Tibet since India's cooperation was desirable for China in international affairs. [37] The Chinese devised their strategy accordingly, and decided not to bring the McMahon Line into the ambit of the discussion since it was not 'ripe for settlement'. This was an excellent example of how China would adjust its strategy and tactics on the basis of facts. India had already presumed that Chinese silence on the matter meant acceptance of the current reality, and the fact that China never raised this issue in the 1954 negotiations only served to convert the presumption into incontrovertible fact. It would prove fatal for India.

In the talks, China's strategy was to secure the full, final and unambiguous acknowledgement from India about Tibet as a part of China; to end all special privileges for India in Tibet; and to put off any discussion about the frontier until a later date.